Know What to Ask Providers Before You Pick Up the Phone

Four prompts to turn your husband's requirements into must-haves, sort what you've heard from what you've confirmed, prepare the questions every provider gets, and build a call sheet that records who said what and when.

Where you are

Your husband needs more care than you can give at home, or the hospital has told you he'll be discharged somewhere else. You've been handed a list of names, friends have opinions, and a directory says who has beds. None of it is confirmed.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can call any agency or facility with the same set of questions, write down the answer, its source, and the date, and know which claims still need checking before you'd trust them.

A one-page Provider Call Sheet: Our must-haves, Questions we ask every provider, and a blank record with source, date, answer, and still to confirm.

Before you start

- The list of what your husband needs help with, from the hospital or your own notes.
- Any names you've been given, with where each came from.
- Your own notes from any calls or visits so far. Even two phone calls are enough to begin.

PROMPT 1

Turn the requirements into must-haves

WHY THIS MATTERS

A provider can only be measured against what your husband needs, and a search without must-haves ends up driven by whoever returns the call first.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

His current care requirements, from discharge papers or your notes, and anything about location and visiting that matters to you.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my husband needs help with, and what matters to our family about location and visiting:
>
> [PASTE HIS REQUIREMENTS]
>
> [PASTE WHAT MATTERS ABOUT LOCATION AND ACCESS]
>
> Sort this into three lists: MUST HAVE (a provider that can't do this is out), STRONGLY PREFER, and NICE TO HAVE. For each must-have, write the one-sentence question I would ask a provider to find out whether they can do it. Do not suggest any provider, agency, or facility, and do not tell me what type of care he needs. Just build the criteria from what I've given you.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A short must-have list. If everything is a must-have, nothing is.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read the must-haves aloud to one other family member and see if they agree.

PROMPT 2

Separate what you've been told from what you've confirmed

WHY THIS MATTERS

By now you've collected names, a brochure, a directory printout, and a cousin's recommendation. All of it feels like information. Only some of it has been checked.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything you've gathered so far, with the provider names taken out or replaced with letters.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've gathered so far about possible providers for my husband. I've replaced the names with letters:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES, NAMES REMOVED]
>
> Put each item in a table with three columns: WHAT I READ OR WAS TOLD, WHERE IT CAME FROM AND WHEN (a directory, a brochure, a provider's own words, a friend, a tour, not sure), and WHAT I'D HAVE TO ASK TO CONFIRM IT. Mark anything about availability, beds, or staffing as

> unconfirmed unless I said I confirmed it myself with a date. Do not compare the providers, rank them, or say which seems better.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How much of what you thought you knew turns out to be a listing or a feeling.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Treat every unconfirmed item as unknown until a provider has confirmed it to you directly.

PROMPT 3

Prepare the questions every provider gets

WHY THIS MATTERS

Asking the same questions of everyone is what makes answers comparable later. It also keeps you from forgetting the night shift, the shared room, or what happens when his needs go up.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your must-haves from Prompt 1.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My husband's must-haves and preferences are below:
>
> [PASTE THE LISTS FROM PROMPT 1]
>
> Write the questions I should ask every provider, in the order I'd ask them on a phone call, under these headings: AVAILABILITY RIGHT NOW, WHO IS ON DUTY DAY AND NIGHT, ROOM AND LIVING ARRANGEMENTS, HIS PARTICULAR NEEDS, and WHAT HAPPENS WHEN HIS NEEDS INCREASE. Phrase each so it asks for a specific answer, not a reassurance. Add one line under each heading reminding me to write down who answered and the date. Do not answer the questions or tell me what a good answer sounds like.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Questions about overnight staffing and about increased needs. Those are the ones families skip.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Make the first call with the list in front of you.

PROMPT 4

Build the call sheet

WHY THIS MATTERS

The sheet isn't a judgment about anyone. It's a place to write down what each provider says, where it came from, and what's still open, so the comparison can happen later with your care consultant.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of Prompts 1 to 3.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are my husband's must-haves, my sorted notes, and my provider questions:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Make me a one-page Provider Call Sheet with three parts: OUR MUST-HAVES as a short list at the top; QUESTIONS WE ASK EVERY PROVIDER, numbered; and a blank RECORD table with the columns Provider, Question number, Answer, Who answered, Date, and Still to confirm. Leave the record empty so I can fill in one copy per call. Do not add any provider names, ratings, scores, or recommendations.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A sheet you could hand to a sibling so they could make the next call for you.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Print or copy it once per provider you plan to call. Then rest a little before the first call.

The questions only work with the requirements behind them

Every question on your call sheet points back to something your husband needs. The care interview writes those needs down as a Family Care Profile, so the sheet, and your care consultant, have a solid file to work from.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›